



— RECAP SAN DIEGO · 17 SEP 2026

THE INFLECTION POINT

DDX'26 San Diego. 25 design and product leaders, one question: if AI makes “good enough” free, what is the job now?

— THE DAY

One day.
Three stages.
One question.

25 SPEAKERS	3 STAGES
9 TABLE TALKS	400+ LEADERS IN THE ROOM

Good is free now. Great is the job.

When everyone can clear the bar for good, taste, judgment and a durable point of view are what separate teams. AI didn't change design; it exposed how shallow most of it was.



Richard Ward, Otter.ai · Kevin Wong, Webflow · Jaleesa Chagan, GAIN

2026 EVIDENCE

91%

of designers now use AI for design tasks every week, up from 54% a year ago.

Designer Fund, AI in Design 2026

Research stops being a project **and** **becomes a pulse.**

When teams ship weekly, episodic studies arrive after the decision. TaylorMade's AI caddie showed the alternative: research before, A/B tests during, evaluation after, always on.



Prayag Narula, Marvin · Harriet Swan, GAIN · Katie Niles,
TaylorMade

2026 EVIDENCE

8 → 22%

of organisations now call research
essential to all levels of business strategy,
nearly tripling in a year.

Maze, Future of User Research 2026

Stop designing screens. **Start designing decisions.**

Design's value is measured by its influence on what gets built, not by deliverables. The next brief is the organisation itself: its systems, ownership and invisible labour.



Chris Gielow, UX Speakeasy · Twisha Shah-Brandenburg, Target · Diana Tobey, IDEO

2026 EVIDENCE

21 → 41%

of designers now do development work, doubling in a year. The roles converge on the decision.

Figma, 2026 AI Report

The human stays irrational, and irreplaceable.

The rational user most products are designed for doesn't exist. AI can read the deck; it can't read the room. As machines generate more, human originality becomes the scarce resource.



Don Norman · Rowan Salama, Careem · Stephanie Mencarelli, Adobe · Kara Fitzpatrick

2026 EVIDENCE

50%

of US consumers prefer brands that don't use generative AI in customer-facing content.

Gartner, March 2026

Context is the asset. The experience is the business.

Models change weekly; structured knowledge compounds. And when an agent is the one browsing and buying, the digital experience is no longer a layer on the business. It is the business.



Diana Wolosin, Netflix · AJ Azzi, Askable · Scott Robinson, FreshForm · Ann Kostopanagiotou, Mondo Robot

2026 EVIDENCE

20 → 77%

AI agents' success rate on real-world tasks, in one year.

Stanford HAI, 2026 AI Index

“The next era of innovation will not belong to the companies that automate the fastest, but to those that intentionally design systems in which humans and intelligent technology can learn, adapt, and make better decisions together.”



Twisha Shah-Brandenburg

Principal, Target

— THE ROOM

Thank you, **San Diego.**



PHOTOS: DESMOND CHUA & NICOLE GOSÉ

SWIPE →

— MADE POSSIBLE BY



Same exchange, next city.

MIAMI

25 Sep 2026

TOKYO

12 Feb 2027

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